

HOW

ABOUT NUMBERS?

Most languages in the Western world use Arabic numerals. As symbols, numbers represent quantity as well as certain qualities. For example, Greek mathematician Pythagoras (c. 569–495 BCE) thought even numbers were feminine and odd numbers were masculine. The number “3” is sacred to many religions (the Christian Holy Trinity and the Hindu Trinity), as is the number “7” (seven chakras in Hindu philosophy, seven branches of the Jewish menorah, seven days a week) and “9” (the nine-story pagoda that symbolizes heaven in China).

WHAT

ABOUT PUNCTUATION?

Punctuation marks were not needed with pictograms, but once more complex language evolved, they became essential. The ancient Greek playwrights used punctuation marks to let the actors reading their lines know when to stop. The Romans also used punctuation for pauses, but the person who pulled punctuation together was Aldus Manutius (1450–1515), the Venetian inventor of italic type, who is credited with standardizing punctuation marks. Full marks to Aldus.

AND

MATH AND COMPUTER SYMBOLS?

Simple tally marks for counting were probably the first to be used. In Egyptian hieroglyphics, the sign for addition resembled a pair of legs going forward, while subtraction was a pair of legs going back. German mathematician Johannes Widmann is credited with inventing the plus and minus signs in 1489. Welshman Robert Recorde invented the equals sign in 1557. On computers, the power button is a combination of the binary symbols for on (a “1”) and off (a “0”). Binary symbols have been used since World War II to label buttons and switches. The USB symbol was drawn to resemble the Olympian God Neptune’s trident. Some people believe that the @ symbol originated in the 500s, when monks used it as a better way of writing the word *ad* (Latin for “at” or “toward”).

WHAT

ABOUT TRAFFIC SIGNS?

Not surprisingly, traffic signs have been designed for maximum impact, with a clear system of colors and shapes that can be understood in an instant. Red means something is prohibited, yellow is for caution, and green is for safety. Triangles are for warnings, while circles show that something is prohibited. It’s all very symbolic.

